that Indian nationalists tend to overlook when they berate Britain for its imperialism!

The father gave thanks to Lord Shiva by building the mighty granite temple of Brihadishvara in Thanjavur. The son responded by building his own Brihadishvara temple in Gangaikondacholapuram but had the courtesy to make its 180-foot-high main tower 10 feet lower than his father's. Both temples are now UNESCO World Heritage Sites. The latter temple has a notice stating that it remained undamaged from the time of its building in 1035 until the arrival of the British, who removed its stones to build a dam. Photographs taken by Alexander Rea in about 1890 before he oversaw the start of the temple's reconstruction show that its surrounding wall, two outer shrines and its entrance *gopuram* lay in ruins (see page 256). However, the damage had been done not by Rea's fellow Britons but by the resurgent Pandyas. In 1279 Raja Maravarman Kulasekara Pandyan I defeated the army of Rajendra Chola III and then set out to destroy the Chola capital, razing every building but the central temple itself. After that there is a no further mention of the Cholas in the records, although the name lingered on in folk memory.

Forty years after that last Chola defeat an entirely novel and devastating form of Islam manifested itself in Tamil country. It came in the form of the cavalry of Sultan Ala-ud-Din Khilji, ruler of Delhi. Threatened by Mongol raiders from the north-west, Ala-ud-Din had hit on a tactic that had been tried many times before in Northern India but never in the South. He embarked on a series of fund-raising raids that each year struck ever deeper into the Deccan and beyond.